

The Great Sūtra Called the Reception by Bimbisāra of Solid Form

Pimpisāra Pratyungamanam Nāma Mahāsūtram · Toh 289 · Derge Kangyur

མདྲ་ཆེ་པ་གྲོགས་ཅན་སྒྲི་པ་སོ་བས་བྱ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ།

The Great Sūtra Called the Reception by Bimbisāra, known in Sanskrit as the Pimpisāra Pratyungamana Mahāsūtra and in Tibetan as Mdo chen po gzugs can snying pos bsu ba, is a canonical Buddhist sūtra recounting the famous meeting between the Buddha and King Bimbisāra of Magadha. The text opens with the Buddha travelling through Magadha accompanied by a great assembly of a thousand monks — all former matted-hair ascetics and accomplished arhats — as he makes his way toward the bamboo grove of Supraṭiṣṭhita, setting the scene for the royal reception that gives the sūtra its name. This narrative belongs to a well-known episode in early Buddhist literature in which the king, having previously pledged to welcome the Buddha upon his attainment of awakening, fulfills that vow. It is Toh 289 in the Kangyur, catalogued among the general sūtras of the canon.

In the language of India: Pimpisāra Pratyungamanam Nāma Mahāsūtram. In the Tibetan language: The Great Sūtra Called the Reception by Bimbisāra of Solid Form.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was travelling through the land of Magadha together with a great Saṅgha of a thousand monks, all of them former matted-hair ascetics, all of them arhats — their defilements exhausted, their task accomplished, their work completed, their burden set down, their own aim fully attained, the bonds of existence utterly worn away, their minds perfectly and completely liberated through right understanding. As he was travelling through the land of Magadha, he set out toward the place of the bamboo grove of Supraṭiṣṭhita, the stūpa of the people of Magadha, and there the Blessed One arrived at Supraṭiṣṭhita and remained in the bamboo grove of Supraṭiṣṭhita, the stūpa of the people of Magadha.

Bimbisāra (Skt. Bimbisāra), king of Magadha, of well-trained and solid form, heard that the Blessed One was travelling through the land of Magadha together with a great Saṅgha of a thousand monks, all of them former matted-hair ascetics, all of them arhats — their defilements exhausted, their

task accomplished, their work completed, their burden set down, their own aim fully attained, the bonds of existence utterly worn away, their minds perfectly and completely liberated through right understanding — and that he had set out toward the place of the bamboo grove of Supraṭiṣṭhita, the stūpa of the people of Magadha, and had arrived there and was now residing in the bamboo grove of Supraṭiṣṭhita, the stūpa of the people of Magadha.

Upon hearing this, the king, by his great royal wealth and great royal power, set out from Rājagṛha with two ten-thousands of carriages, eight ten-thousands of horse troops, and many hundreds of thousands of the brahmins and householders of the land of Magadha, in order to go and see the Blessed One and pay homage to him. He rode as far as the ground permitted a vehicle to go, then dismounted and entered the park on foot alone. At the point from which King Bimbisāra of Magadha, of well-trained and solid form, could see the Blessed One, he removed and set aside the five royal emblems: the crown, the parasol, the sword, the jewelled fly-whisk, and the patterned sandals.

Then, having removed and set aside the five royal emblems, King Bimbisāra of Magadha, of well-trained and solid form, went toward where the Blessed One was. On arriving, he arranged his outer robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and, pressing his palms together in the direction of the Blessed One, bowed down. He then announced himself: "Venerable One, I am Bimbisāra, king of Magadha, of well-trained and solid form. Venerable One, I am Bimbisāra, king of Magadha, of well-trained and solid form — I am the king." Three times in this way he proclaimed his own name.

The Blessed One declared: "Great king, it is so. It is indeed so. Great king, you are Bimbisāra, king of Magadha, of well-trained and solid form. Great king, you are Bimbisāra, king of Magadha, of well-trained and solid form — you are the king. Great king, please be seated on whatever seat is yours."

Then King Bimbisāra of Magadha, of well-trained and solid form, bowed down with his head at the feet of the Blessed One and sat to one side. Some of the brahmins and householders of Magadha also bowed down with their heads at the feet of the Blessed One and sat to one side. Others exchanged with the Blessed One face-to-face greetings of mutual joy,

exchanged pleasant and joyful words of various kinds, and sat to one side. Others joined their palms in the direction of the Blessed One, bowed in reverence, and sat to one side. Others, upon merely seeing the Blessed One

from a great distance, said nothing at all and sat to one side.

Now at that very time, the Venerable Uruvilva Kāśyapa and his whole retinue of matted-hair ascetics had assembled there and were sitting together. Then the brahmins and householders of Magadha began to wonder: "Is it that the great ascetic Uruvilva Kāśyapa is practicing the holy life under the Blessed One, or is it that Uruvilva Kāśyapa himself is practicing the holy life in the presence of the great ascetic?"

The Blessed One, knowing in his mind the thoughts of the brahmins and householders of Magadha, addressed the Venerable Uruvilva Kāśyapa in verse:

"You who have dwelt in Uruvilva, what did you perceive here
that led you to abandon fire and practice austerity alone?
How did you come to give up your fire-oblation rites?
Tell me, Kāśyapa, the reason for this."

The Venerable Uruvilva Kāśyapa replied in verse:

"It is because I clearly saw those things to be impure —
the foods and drinks, the flavors, the pleasures, the women that oblations
celebrate,
those material goods arising from such rites.
That is why I take no joy in the oblation-fire."

The Blessed One then declared:

"If, then, your mind finds no genuine delight
in sensual pleasures, food and drink, and likewise in flavors,
tell me, Kāśyapa, what is it that brings your mind joy
in the worlds of gods and humans?"

The Venerable Uruvilva Kāśyapa replied:

"I have seen a state — the supreme peace — without aggregates,
without anything at all, free from attachment to the realm of desire,
unchanging and not led by others.
That is why I take no joy in the oblation-fire.
When I had not yet seen that unspoiled, sublime state,
I was bewildered, deceived into thinking that through oblation-rites and
austerities
one could be liberated,
and I foolishly went on following birth and death.
O Gautama, who guides the many to their welfare,

who are endowed with the power of truth — a sage who has arisen — through the excellent teaching of the supreme protector, I have now seen that unconditioned state."

The Blessed One then declared:

"You have understood what is true among the widely analyzed phenomena — you have not reflected wrongly; you have correctly realized with certainty. Kāśyapa, let your retinue not be disheartened."

Thereupon, having been given this opening by the Blessed One, the Venerable Uruvilva Kāśyapa entered a meditative absorption such that he became invisible upon his own seat, just as one steadies the mind in equipoise. He then rose up into the sky above the eastern direction and performed the four modes of deportment — walking, standing, sitting, and lying down. He then entered absorption on the fire element, and from the body of the Venerable Uruvilva Kāśyapa as he rested in that absorption on the fire element, rays of light of various kinds arose — blue, yellow, red, white, orange, and crystal-like. He also displayed pairs of miracles: from the lower part of his body flames blazed while from the upper part streams of cold water flowed down, and from the upper part of his body flames blazed while from the lower part streams of cold water flowed down. Just as he had done in the sky above the eastern direction, he likewise rose up into the sky above the south, the west, and the north, and performed the four modes of deportment — walking, standing, sitting, and lying down.

He also entered into absorption on the fire element. From the body of the venerable Uruvilva Kāśyapa, who had entered into absorption on the fire element, rays of light of various kinds arose — blue, yellow, red, white, orange, and crystal-like. He also displayed pairs of miracles: from the lower part of his body flames blazed while from the upper part streams of cold water flowed down, and from the upper part of his body flames blazed while from the lower part streams of cold water flowed down. Having thus displayed the four modes of miraculous power in the four directions, he gathered back those miraculous displays, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, turned toward the Blessed One, joined his palms together in reverence, and spoke these words to the Blessed One: "The Blessed One is my Teacher. I am a śrāvaka of the Blessed One. The Blessed One is my Teacher —

my Teacher. I am a śrāvaka of the Blessed One — a śrāvaka."

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, it is so. It is indeed so. Kāśyapa, I am your Teacher. You are my śrāvaka. Kāśyapa, I am your Teacher — your Teacher. You are my śrāvaka — my śrāvaka. Kāśyapa, sit now upon your own seat."

Then the venerable Uruvilva Kāśyapa prostrated with his head at the feet of the Blessed One and sat down upon his own seat.

Thereupon the brahmins and householders of the land of Magadha thought to themselves: "The great renunciant is not one who has lived the holy life under the matted-haired ascetic Uruvilva Kāśyapa; rather, it is the matted-haired ascetic Uruvilva Kāśyapa himself who has lived the holy life in the presence of the great monk."

Then the Blessed One spoke to Bimbisāra, king of the land of Magadha: "Great King, form neither arises nor ceases, yet its arising and ceasing are to be understood. Great King, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness neither arise nor cease, yet their arising and ceasing are likewise to be understood. Great King, a person of good family who understands the nature of reality — that form arises and ceases — fully comprehends that form. Great King, a person of good family who understands the nature of reality — that feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness arise and cease — fully comprehends that consciousness. Great King, a person of good family who fully comprehends form does not claim it as self or mine, does not cling to it, does not dwell in further attachment to it, and does not fixate upon it. Great King, a person of good family who fully comprehends feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness does not claim them as self or mine, does not cling to them, does not dwell in them with further attachment, and does not fixate upon them. Great King, I declare that a person of good family who does not claim form as mine, does not assert it as self, does not cling to it, does not dwell in further attachment to it, and does not fixate upon it — such a one is immeasurable and incalculable, and has attained nirvāṇa. Great King, I declare that a person of good family who does not claim feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as mine, does not assert them as self, does not cling to them, does not dwell in further attachment to them, and does not fixate upon them — such a one is immeasurable and incalculable, and has attained nirvāṇa."

Then the brahmins and householders of the land of Magadha thought to themselves: if form is not self, and feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are equally not self, then who is it that never was in the past, will not come to be in the future, and does not exist even now — and yet, in each and every one of those states, performs virtuous and non-virtuous actions, and individually experiences the karmic maturation of what has been done? And who is it that, abandoning these aggregates and taking up a connection with other aggregates, is a self, a sentient being, a life, a birth, a nourishment, a person, one born of seed, an offspring, a doer, one who sets doing in motion, a producer, an utter producer, an arouser, an utter arouser, a speaker, an experiencer, an individual experiencer — who, then, is this?

Then the Blessed One, knowing the minds of the brahmins and householders of the land of Magadha through his knowledge of others' minds, declared to the monks: "Monks, the ordinary childish person who lacks learning falls into the habit of designating 'self, self' — yet in that there is no self and nothing that belongs to a self.

Monks, this suffering that arises does arise, and suffering that ceases does cease. Formations that arise do arise, and formations that cease do cease. In dependence upon those causes and those conditions, the stream of formations in sentient beings comes to flow. Monks, the Tathāgata, having comprehended the continuation of the stream of formations, arranges the death and birth of sentient beings.

Monks, with my divine eye, utterly purified and far surpassing human faculties, I behold sentient beings as they pass away and are reborn — those of fine appearance and those of coarse appearance, those of low station and those of high, those going to happy destinies and those going to ill. I know precisely how these beings, endowed with awareness, who are possessed of misconduct in body, speech, and mind, who revile the noble ones, who hold wrong views, and who on account of their wrong-view actions and their taking up of such things dissolve at death and thereafter, through those very causes and conditions, fall into ruin, into misfortune, into the downward plunge, and are reborn among the beings of hell. And I know precisely how these beings, endowed with awareness, who are possessed of good conduct in body, speech, and mind, who do not revile the noble ones, who hold right views, and who on account of their right-view actions and their taking up of such things dissolve at death and thereafter, through those very causes and conditions, are reborn in a happy destiny, in a higher world, among the gods. Thus, of the beings as

they go forth from life, I know fully and correctly each as they truly are.

Monks, knowing thus and seeing thus, I do not say that what never was in the past, will not come to be in the future, and does not exist even now — and yet in each and every one of those states performs virtuous and non-virtuous actions and individually experiences the karmic maturation of what has been done — and what, abandoning these aggregates and taking up a connection with other aggregates, is a self, a sentient being, a life, a birth, a nourishment, a person, one born of seed, an offspring, a doer, one who sets doing in motion, a producer, an utter producer, an arouser, an utter arouser, a speaker, an experiencer, an individual experiencer — I do not say that any such thing exists, except as a conventional designation of the Dharma.

And this is that conventional designation of the Dharma — namely: because this exists, this arises; because this has arisen, this comes to be — that is to say:"

Through the condition of ignorance, formations arise. Through the condition of formations, consciousness. Through the condition of consciousness, name-and-form. Through the condition of name-and-form, the six sense sources. Through the condition of the six sense sources, contact. Through the condition of contact, feeling. Through the condition of feeling, craving. Through the condition of craving, grasping. Through the condition of grasping, becoming. Through the condition of becoming, birth. Through the condition of birth, aging and death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, mental distress, and anguish arise. In this way does this entire great mass of suffering come into being.

And this is how it is: because this does not exist, this does not arise; because this has ceased, this ceases — that is to say: through the cessation of ignorance, formations cease. Through the cessation of formations, consciousness ceases. Through the cessation of consciousness, name-and-form ceases. Through the cessation of name-and-form, the six sense sources cease. Through the cessation of the six sense sources, contact ceases. Through the cessation of contact, feeling ceases. Through the cessation of feeling, craving ceases. Through the cessation of craving, grasping ceases. Through the cessation of grasping, becoming ceases. Through the cessation of becoming, birth ceases. Through the cessation of birth, aging and death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering, mental distress, and anguish cease. In this way does this entire great mass of suffering cease.

Monks, thus it is that formations are suffering, and nirvāṇa is peace. From the arising of causes, all suffering arises; and from the cessation of causes, suffering ceases — the stream of the path is cut off, it no longer arises, it forms no further continuity, and it comes to cessation. Such, exactly, is the end of suffering. Monks, apart from the cessation of whatever is suffering, its subsiding, its cooling, and its extinction, who is there that is fully liberated? Monks, it is this — the complete relinquishing of the aggregates, the exhaustion of craving, freedom from attachment, cessation, the attainment of nirvāṇa — this is peace.

Then the Blessed One spoke a second time to Ajātaśatru, king of Magadha, the embodiment of artful refinement: "Great King, what do you think — is form permanent or impermanent?"

The king replied: "Venerable One, it is impermanent."

The Blessed One declared: "Great King, that which is impermanent — is it suffering or not suffering?"

The king replied: "Venerable One, it is suffering."

The Blessed One declared: "Great King, then that which is impermanent, suffering, and subject to change — do the noble śrāvakas who have heard the teaching claim of it, 'This is mine, this is I, this is my self'?"

The king replied: "Venerable One, they do not."

The Blessed One declared: "Great King, what do you think — are feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness permanent or impermanent?"

The king replied: "Venerable One, they are impermanent."

The Blessed One declared: "Great King, that which is impermanent — is it suffering or not suffering?"

The king replied: "Venerable One, it is suffering."

The Blessed One declared: "Great King, then that which is impermanent, suffering, and subject to change — do the noble śrāvakas who have heard the teaching claim of it, 'This is mine, this is I, this is my self'?"

The king replied: "Venerable One, they do not."

The Blessed One declared: "Great King, therefore, whatever form there may be — past, future, or present; internal or external; gross or subtle; inferior or superior; far or near — all of it should be seen as it truly is, with genuine

wisdom: 'This does not belong to me. This is not I. This is not my self.' Whatever feeling, perception, formations, and whatever consciousness there may be — past, future, or present; internal or external; gross or subtle; inferior or superior; far or near — all of it should be seen as it truly is, with genuine wisdom: 'This does not belong to me. This is not I. This is not my self.'

Great King, a noble śrāvaka who is learned and who sees things in this way becomes disenchanted with form, disenchanted with feeling, perception, formations, and disenchanted with consciousness. Through disenchantment, attachment falls away. Through the falling away of attachment, liberation comes. Through liberation, one knows: 'Birth is exhausted; the holy life has been lived; what had to be done has been done; there is no knowing of another existence beyond this.' Thus one knows and sees that one is liberated.

When this exposition of the Dharma was taught, Bimbisāra, King of Magadha, together with eighty thousand gods, and the brahmin and householder communities of Magadha, numbering many hundreds of thousands, gained the pure and stainless eye of Dharma with respect to all phenomena.

Then Bimbisāra, King of Magadha, having seen the Dharma, attained the Dharma, understood the Dharma, and reached to the very depth of the Dharma — having crossed beyond doubt, crossed beyond uncertainty, no longer dependent on others, not to be led astray by others, and having gained fearlessness with regard to the Dharma of the Teacher's teaching — rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, knelt with his right knee on the ground, and, joining his palms in homage toward the Blessed One, addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Venerable One, I have entered the stream. I have entered the stream. I take refuge in the Blessed One, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha of monks. From today onward, for as long as I live, having abandoned the taking of life and the rest, as one who has taken refuge and who has become filled with faith, may I be received as a lay practitioner. For as long as I live I wish to attend upon the Blessed One together with the Saṅgha of monks with robes, alms-food, lodging, seats, and medicines and provisions for the sick. May the Blessed One graciously consent to come to Rājagṛha."

The Blessed One signaled his consent to Bimbisāra, King of Magadha, by remaining silent.

Then Bimbisāra, King of Magadha, understanding from the Blessed One's silence that consent had been given, praised the words of the Blessed One and

rejoiced in them, bowed with his head to the feet of the Blessed One, and departed from the presence of the Blessed One.

This concludes the Great Sūtra known as "The Invitation of Bimbisāra."

Translated by the Indian masters Jinamitra, Prajñāvarman, and the great editor-translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, and others; revised and finalized.

Translator's Notes

- The Sanskrit title preserved at the opening, Pimpisāra Pratyungamanaṃ Nāma Mahāsūtram, corresponds to the Tibetan title meaning "The Great Sūtra Called the Going Forth to Receive Bimbisāra" or "The Reception of Bimbisāra." The name Bimbisāra is rendered from the Tibetan phonetic form Bzos byangs gzugs can snying po, which is a Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit Bimbisāra, meaning "one with a body of solid, well-formed substance." The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the supplied passage; no closing formula is present.
- The phrase rendered "unconditioned state" translates a term literally meaning "the uncompounded" or "the unformed" — referring to the unconditioned, which in this context Uruvilva Kāśyapa identifies with the supreme peace of nirvāṇa. The paired fire-and-water miracles are the classic "twin miracle" display attributed in Pāli and Sanskrit sources to spiritually advanced disciples; the text here follows that standard template. "Pairs of miracles" renders the Tibetan term for this display literally.
- The Tibetan name འཇའ་མཁའ་ལྷོ་མཆོག་ལྷོ་མཆོག་ལྷོ་མཆོག་ is the Tibetan rendering of Bimbisāra, king of Magadha. The name literally means something like "one whose body has the essence of a refined form," but this is a phonetic-semantic rendering of the Sanskrit Bimbisāra, and it is rendered as Bimbisāra throughout.

The repeated alternation between "does not claim as self or mine," "does not cling," "does not dwell in further attachment," and "does not fixate upon" renders four distinct Tibetan verbs expressing graduated forms of self-grasping and clinging: asserting ownership, grasping as one's own, settling into habitual attachment, and manifestly fixating. The slight variation between the two parallel passages — one uses འཇའ་མཁའ་ལྷོ་མཆོག་ལྷོ་མཆོག་ ("does not dwell in further attachment") and the other འཇའ་མཁའ་ལྷོ་མཆོག་ལྷོ་མཆོག་ ("does not dwell further in it") — reflects a genuine textual variation in the Tibetan; both have been rendered as naturally as possible in the parallel structure.

- The phrase rendered "conventional designation of the Dharma" translates "chos kyi brda," literally "a sign or convention of the Dharma." This is a significant technical expression pointing to dependent origination as a mere conventional label, not as designating any ultimately real entity such as a self. The passage is essentially a classic formulation of the no-self doctrine paired with dependent origination, and the Blessed One's answer to the laypersons' implicit objection — if there is no self, who acts and experiences? — is precisely this: it is only a conventional designation, the formula of which is then introduced by the final line (the text breaks off just before the full formula of dependent origination is stated).
- The royal epithet translated as "the embodiment of artful refinement" renders འཇའ་མཁའ་ལྷོ་མཆོག་, literally "one possessed of a form refined by craft or artistry," a poetic royal epithet for Ajātaśatru. Its precise referent is somewhat uncertain; it may allude to physical bearing, aesthetic cultivation, or a specific epithetic tradition surrounding this king. The rendering is interpretive rather than literal, but captures the honorific register.
- The king's name rendered here as "Bimbisāra" corresponds to the Tibetan "bzo sbyaṅs gzugs

can sñiñ po," a translation of the Sanskrit Bimbisāra. The colophon names the standard team of Jinamitra, Prajñāvarman, and Yeshe Dé responsible for many canonical translations of this period. The phrase "entered the stream" renders Tibetan "mñon par žugs pa," the standard equivalent of Sanskrit srotaāpanna, denoting the first of the four noble attainments, here used twice in the king's declaration for emphasis.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.